

Sociology Module

Exam Preparation Guide

Introduction to Human Sciences (IHS)
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Synthesised from Lectures, Transcripts, Slides, Class Notes & All
Readings

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Chapter 1

What is Sociology? The Sociological Imagination

1.1 Defining Sociology

Sociology is the systematic study of **societies, social groups, and the theorisation of all forms of societal interaction**. Its central task is to identify *broad patterns* in how societies function and, on the basis of those patterns, to develop an understanding of *why people behave the way they do*.

An important starting question: is sociology just “common sense”? Most of us already talk about social issues in everyday life, so is it just dressed-up gossip? The answer is *no*. Sociology goes beyond common sense by being **systematic, evidence-based, and theoretical**. It forces us to question what we take for granted.

Core Concept: Sociology Defined

The study of *societies, individuals, groups, and the relationship between them*. It examines social structures (how society is organised), social institutions (family, religion, education, law), and social processes (migration, urbanisation, power, conflict).

Social Structure

The ways in which societies categorise people into distinct positions—stratifying human societies by **class, gender, caste**, and other axes of differentiation.

Social Institution

Established patterns of social relationships (family, education, economy, government) that shape individual experiences and societal outcomes.

Social Process

Dynamic phenomena such as **urbanisation, industrialisation, digitalisation** through which social structures evolve over time.

1.1.1 Key Concerns of Sociology

Sociology covers a wide range:

- **Social Institutions:** Caste, Class, Tribe/Ethnicity, Gender, Religion, Family.
- **Social Processes:** How power and authority work, urbanisation, migration, industrialisation, ecological change, and social movements—struggles for change and resistance to it.

Case Study: The “Drinking Coffee” Exercise

At first, coffee seems like just a drink. But sociologically it is a *symbol* of social status (a café vs. instant coffee), a *ritual* (morning routines), a *global product* (grown by poor farmers in Africa, consumed by rich countries), and part of a wider social world. When you start seeing ordinary things this way—that is sociology at work.

Case Study: A University as a Social Institution

A university is not just a building for learning. It is a space that produces and spreads knowledge, a tool for social mobility (a poor student can change their life), a melting pot of cultures, and a space for dissent (students protesting injustice). Sociology helps us see all these layers at once.

Case Study: Hurricane Katrina — Peter Berger’s “Seeing the General in the Particular”

Sociologist Peter Berger described sociological thinking as “seeing the general in the particular”—looking at one individual or event and finding the broader social pattern behind it. When Hurricane Katrina hit New Orleans it seemed like a natural disaster. But sociology revealed that *poor, Black communities suffered far more*—showing that “natural” disasters are actually shaped by social inequality.

Critical Reflection: From Class Notes — 23 March

The professor emphasised: “Understand the problem before moving to the solution.” Sociology’s value lies not in prescribing answers but in asking the right questions about the social world. This distinguishes it from engineering-style problem-solving where students often jump to solutions.

1.2 The Sociological Imagination

The concept was coined by **C. Wright Mills** (1959). It asks us to connect *personal troubles* to *public issues*—to see how individual biographies are embedded in broader historical and structural contexts.

Core Concept: The Sociological Imagination — C. Wright Mills

“Neither the life of an individual nor the history of a society can be understood without understanding both.” The sociological imagination means being able to connect your personal troubles to larger public issues. It asks: what role does society play in shaping your individual choices?

Biography and History

Individual life stories are inseparable from the historical moment in which they

unfold. A factory worker's experience during the Industrial Revolution cannot be understood without understanding industrialisation itself.

Personal Troubles vs. Public Issues

Unemployment feels personal, but when millions are unemployed it becomes a structural issue requiring sociological—not merely psychological—explanation.

Questioning the Taken-for-Granted

The sociological imagination involves *defamiliarising* everyday life: asking why things we consider “natural” (eating habits, marriage norms, career aspirations) are actually products of social forces.

Paths of Least Resistance

Sociologist Allan Johnson explains that we participate in social *systems*—family, school, religion, economy. These systems shape us through **socialisation** (we learn what is “normal”) and through **paths of least resistance** (we tend to follow what society expects, even without being told to). But at the same time, *we make social systems happen*—by following norms, we keep those systems alive.

Case Study: Unemployment — Personal Trouble or Public Issue?

If one person loses their job, that is a personal problem—maybe they need to work harder. But if millions lose their jobs during an economic recession, that is a public issue, caused by structural forces in the economy. The sociological imagination helps us shift from blaming the individual to understanding the system.

Interdisciplinary Link

Psychology ↔ Sociology: While psychology focuses on individual cognition and behaviour, sociology insists that these are profoundly shaped by external social structures. The sociological imagination warns against **reductionism**—reducing complex social phenomena to individual or biological factors.

Exam Alert

Key distinction: The sociological imagination is *not* merely thinking about society. It is the capacity to shift between the personal and the structural, to see how private lives are shaped by public forces. Exam answers should demonstrate this “shuttling” between levels of analysis.

1.3 The Social Contract

An **implicit agreement** among members of a society to cooperate and abide by certain rules and norms. It underlies the relationship between citizens and the state and has real-world consequences for how rights are exercised.

Case Study: Right to Information (RTI) Act in India

The RTI Act allows citizens to request information from government agencies, promoting transparency. However, the state frequently cites privacy concerns to withhold information. This tension illustrates how the social contract is *contested*—rights exist on paper but their exercise depends on power dynamics between citizens and institutions.

Data → Information → Knowledge → Wisdom

A hierarchy from handwritten notes. **Data** is raw and unprocessed; **Information** is meaningful, contextualised data; **Knowledge** involves deeper understanding; **Wisdom** implies the capacity to act well on that understanding. For farmers, raw weather *data* becomes actionable *information* only when it tells them when to spend on seeds.

Right to Privacy

Intersects with RTI—digital technologies complicate these dynamics by generating vast quantities of personal data that both enable and threaten individual rights.

1.4 Digitalisation, Platformization, and the Attention Economy

1.4.1 Digitalisation

The conversion of information, services, and products into digital formats. This transforms societal structures with implications for social movements, activism, and governance.

1.4.2 Platformization

The rise of platforms (Facebook, Google, etc.) as integral intermediaries in modern life. They facilitate connections and economic transactions but simultaneously raise concerns about **privacy**, **surveillance**, and the **exploitation of personal data**.

Digital Intermediation

Platforms can facilitate access to services but also create new inequalities—particularly in informal economies and for marginalised communities.

Dromology

From handwritten notes: the study of *movements* and speed in society; relevant to how digital platforms accelerate social interactions and compress decision-making time.

Polarization

Digital platforms reduce complex choices to binary options (swipe left/right, like/dislike), creating a “Yes/No” world that erodes nuance.

1.4.3 Influencer Culture and the Economy of Attention

Lifestyle Influencers

Particularly from *mofussil* (small-town) areas, driven by desire for social mobility and economic opportunity.

Relatability

The core strategy: content that makes audiences feel “this person is just like me.” This manufactured intimacy is the currency of the attention economy.

Bartering in Informal Economies

Influencers engage in **altruistic bartering**—exchanging goods/services (clothing, makeup) for social media promotion—bypassing traditional monetary transactions.

Yuganthar & “Human in the Loop”

From handwritten notes: even in digital economies, human judgement, agency, and labour remain essential—technology does not operate autonomously.

Critical Reflection: De-skilling and AI

The professor discussed how AI and automation lead to **de-skilling**: humans lose confidence and competence in areas where machines take over. This connects to Marx’s concept of alienation (Chapter 4)—workers become estranged from the process and product of their labour.

1.5 Urbanisation

The process of rapid urban growth fundamentally reshapes individual experience, social outcomes, and economic activity.

- Cities are created by the influx of people, technologies, and capital.
- Driven by the desire for efficiency and profit—which can lead to displacement and marginalisation.
- Before the Industrial Revolution, only 10% of the European population lived in cities; by 1850 this rose to 52% in England, 25% in France, 36% in Germany.
- Results in a **definitive break from feudalism**: family structures, modes of production, and class structures all transformed.

Chapter 2

Historical Roots of Modern Sociology

2.1 The European Context: Why Sociology Emerged

Sociology arose in response to a cluster of revolutionary transformations in 17th–19th century Europe. The discipline was given a **mandate to explain** these changes. Crucially, *sociological theories are embedded in a particular social context*—every thinker responds to the problems of their time. There is an “inner context” (the thinker’s own background) and an “outer context” (the broader society). Both together produce theory.

2.1.1 The Scientific Revolution & Enlightenment

- Key figures: **Copernicus, Kepler, Galileo, Newton.**
- Emergence of the **scientific method**: evidence, observation, experimentation, measurement, hypothesis.
- Erosion of the influence of **faith and religion** as the primary source of knowledge.
- New ways of thinking—*questioning authority* (from handwritten notes: “Scientific Revolution = Questioning authority. Without methodology, no science.”).

2.1.2 The French Revolution (1789)

Thinkers like Montesquieu, Rousseau, and later Comte were forced to grapple with questions of social order and what holds society together. Comte and Durkheim, in particular, were deeply worried about the social chaos that followed the revolution—and sociology was partly their attempt to restore order *scientifically*.

2.1.3 The Industrial Revolution

- Structural change: lesser role for the agrarian sector; shift to large-scale manufacturing.
- New sources of power revolutionised production.
- Rapid urbanisation and migration to cities.

- Created a new class of poor workers (proletariat) working long hours for low wages—creating massive inequality and social movements.
- Definitive break from feudalism.

2.1.4 Revolutions and the Rise of Nation-States

- French Revolution, American Revolution—challenges to monarchy.
- The idea of an **accountable government** that people could change.
- Key Enlightenment thinkers: **Montesquieu, Edmund Burke, Kant, Rousseau, Descartes, Locke, Tocqueville, Saint-Simon, Auguste Comte.**
- Emergence of a new “science of society.”

2.1.5 The Rise of Individualism

- Decline of the Catholic Church; rise of the **Protestant Church** and individual interpretation of scripture.
- Shift from **inherited/ascribed status** to **achieved status**—choices and decisions acquired importance.

2.1.6 European Colonialism

As Europe conquered new territories, it needed to understand the “other”—the people it was ruling. This is where sociology and anthropology were born in the colonies. Colonial officers and missionaries began documenting the languages, customs, and social practices of colonised peoples—but often through a biased lens that saw Western civilisation as superior.

2.2 The Counter-Enlightenment

Not everyone welcomed the Enlightenment. **Conservative thinkers** like De Bonald wanted to return to the medieval period, seeing the revolutions as destructive to harmony, law, and order. They emphasised:

- *Collectivity* over the individual.
- The value of tradition and established institutions.
- Opposition to rapid social change.

This tension between the progressive Enlightenment thinkers and the conservative Counter-Enlightenment produced the debates that early sociology was born from. Durkheim’s concern with *social order* and *consensus* carries traces of this conservative tradition, even though his prescriptions were forward-looking.

2.3 European Colonisation and the “Other”

- Spread of European colonisation and the “discovery” of new land masses.

- Growth of capitalism fuelled by **huge wealth transferred from the colonies to Europe**.
- Need to understand the “**Other**”—sociology and anthropology emerged partly as tools for colonial administration.

The Concept of “Othering”

Creating and maintaining social boundaries that distinguish “us” from “them.” Colonial powers portrayed colonised peoples as inferior, uncivilised, or exotic to justify domination—often under the guise of a “civilising mission.”

Colonisation as a Two-Phase Process

From handwritten notes: **Phase I**—Colonisation (arrival and conquest); **Phase II**—Stay and Rule (establishment of administrative and knowledge systems to maintain control).

Case Study: The Design of Colonial Knowledge

A British woman writing about India in the 1920s argued that “the conditions of the Indian masses are due to their cultural primitiveness” and that “the British are the best thing to happen to them.” This exemplifies how colonial knowledge production constructed the colonised as the “Other” to legitimise imperial rule.

Case Study: Online Dating and the Design of Intimacy

A French scholar’s research on how online dating platforms (e.g., Tinder) have transformed intimacy. The design of swiping—reducing a person to a binary accept/reject—creates **commodification** of potential partners. Platforms flatten complex human beings into consumable profiles: a contemporary form of “othering.”

Chapter 3

Auguste Comte and Positivism

Key Thinker: Auguste Comte (1798–1857)

Known as the **Father of Sociology**—not because he wrote the best sociology, but because he first argued that society *could and should* be studied scientifically, just like physics or chemistry. He coined the very word “Sociology” in 1838.

Comte was deeply worried by the social disorder following the French Revolution. His response was to create a *science of society* that would bring back stability and order. He envisioned sociology as more complex than mathematics, astronomy, physics, chemistry, or biology—calling it the “**queen of sciences**.”

3.1 Positivism

Core Concept: Positivism — Comte’s Core Philosophy

Positivism holds that society can be studied using the same methods as natural science—through observation, comparison, and experiment. Knowledge is only valid if it is based on evidence. Supernatural or metaphysical explanations are rejected. This idea spread across Europe and influenced all later sociologists.

3.2 Social Statics and Social Dynamics

Comte divided sociology into two parts:

Social Statics

How society maintains equilibrium and balance. The study of order, cohesion, and what holds society together.

Social Dynamics

How society changes and progresses over time. The study of social evolution and development.

Comte stressed the *interconnectedness* of all parts of society (society as a whole system)

and believed in *consensus*—that people need to agree on basic values for society to function. He was *not* a supporter of violent revolution.

3.3 The Law of Three Stages

Comte’s most famous contribution: every society, and indeed all human knowledge, passes through three stages in a fixed order.

Stage	Period	What Explains the World?
Theological	Up to ~1300	God, spirits, supernatural powers explain everything. The world is God’s creation.
Metaphysical	~1300–1800	Abstract forces like “nature” and “reason” replace God, but no scientific laws yet.
Positivistic (Scientific)	1800 onwards	Science and empirical laws explain everything. No God or metaphysics—just observable facts.

For Comte, it was *intellectual confusion*—mixing up these stages—that led to social disorder. True order would come only when the positivistic stage fully dominated. He believed sociology, as the highest science, would ultimately guide society toward order and progress.

Exam Alert

Comte coined “Sociology” in 1838, but it was **Durkheim** who gave the discipline its rigorous methods. Comte is the *namer*; Durkheim is the *methodologist*. Don’t confuse the two.

Chapter 4

Karl Marx: Historical Materialism and Capitalism

4.1 Context: The Central Question

All three founding fathers—**Marx, Durkheim, Weber**—ask the same question: *Why does capitalism emerge as the dominant mode of economic production in 18th-century Europe?* Yet each arrives at a **radically different answer** because their foundational assumptions, methods, and political commitments differ.

Critical Reflection: Why Three Different Answers?

In social science, “two plus two is not always four.” Different **methodologies** → different **foundational assumptions** → different **conclusions**. Unlike the natural sciences, multiple competing frameworks can coexist—each providing genuine insights that the others cannot. The best critiques emerge precisely because an argument is so strong that scholars *must* engage with it even while disagreeing. “The process of arriving at an answer is as important as the answer itself.”

Key Thinker: Karl Marx (1818–1883) & Friedrich Engels (1820–1895)

One of the most celebrated academic collaborations in history. “Marxist theory” refers to the joint work of Marx *and* Engels unless otherwise stated.

Unlike Comte, who wanted to preserve order, Marx wanted to understand *why* society was unjust—and to *change* it.

Note: Karl with a **K**—German spelling.

4.2 Historical Materialism

4.2.1 The Starting Point: Materialism vs. Idealism

Marx’s whole framework begins with a simple but radical idea: the foundation of any society is not its religion, laws, or ideas—it is the *economic base*.

Marx was influenced by the German philosopher **Hegel**, who used the idea of **dialectics**—history moves through contradictions (thesis → antithesis → synthesis). But Hegel focused on *ideas* (**idealism**) as the driving force of history. Marx “flipped” this:

Hegel (Idealism)	Marx (Materialism)
Ideas and consciousness drive history	Material conditions (economics) drive history
The “Absolute Idea” unfolds through history	Class struggle and productive forces unfold through history

Marx said: “It is not the consciousness of men that determines their existence, but their social existence that determines their consciousness.”

4.2.2 Base and Superstructure

Core Concept: Modes of Production

A “mode of production” combines: **Productive Forces** (labour, tools, land, technology—*what* you use to produce) and **Relations of Production** (who owns what—ownership patterns and power). Together these form the **economic base**. Everything else—law, politics, religion, family, art, education—is the **superstructure** built on top.

Think of it as a building. The economic base is the foundation; the superstructure is the walls and roof. The superstructure *reflects and maintains* the base. When the base changes (e.g., feudalism to capitalism), the whole superstructure eventually changes too.

4.2.3 Historical Stages and Class Struggle

Marx saw all of human history as a story of **class struggle**:

Slave Society

Masters vs. Slaves.

Feudalism

Feudal lords vs. Serfs.

Capitalism

Bourgeoisie (owners/capitalists) vs. Proletariat (workers).

Socialism → Communism

(Predicted) Collective ownership; no class division.

History follows a **dialectical path**: Primitive Communism → Feudalism → Capitalism → Socialism → Communism. Each stage contains the seeds of its own destruction through internal contradictions. This is **dialectical materialism**.

4.3 Social Stratification: A Marxist View

Class Defined by one's *relationship to the means of production*. The fundamental divide: **bourgeoisie** (who own the means of production) vs. **proletariat** (who sell their labour).

Class Conflict

The engine of historical change. The interests of bourgeoisie and proletariat are structurally opposed—profit requires exploitation of labour.

The Individual as Product of the System

Marx does *not* study individual capitalists as the problem. The **system** creates individuals like Elon Musk—they are byproducts of capitalism. “Elon Musk does not create capitalism; capitalism creates Elon Musk.”

Case Study: Caste in a Marxist Framework

The lecture notes make an important point: caste was *not* always birth-based. It *became* a rigid birth-based system through historical processes. Marxists ask: how and why did stratification happen? What economic interests did it serve? Classes are primarily economic—shaped by who owns what.

4.4 Surplus Value and Exploitation

Core Concept: Surplus Value

In capitalism, workers are paid wages. But they produce *more value* than they receive in wages. This extra value—**surplus value**—is taken by the capitalist as profit. This is the root of exploitation. The worker is separated from the product of their own labour.

The greater the surplus value extracted, the greater the profit, and the greater the alienation of the worker.

4.5 Alienation

Marx's explanation for **dysfunction in modern European society** centres on **alienation** (*Entfremdung*)—the estrangement of workers under capitalism.

From the Product of Labour

Workers produce goods over which they have no ownership or control.

From the Process of Labour

Work becomes repetitive, fragmented, and meaningless—the worker is a cog in a machine.

From Fellow Workers

Competition replaces solidarity.

From Nature

Nature is reduced to a resource to be commodified and exploited. Everything

becomes transactional—“water can be bought and sold, air can be bought and sold.”

Case Study: *The Gods Must Be Crazy*

The professor cited this film: a tribal guide in Africa sends up a prayer before killing an animal for food, apologising to it as a fellow living being. The Western characters are baffled—for them, animals exist solely to be consumed. This captures the Marxist insight that capitalism severs the deep human connection with the natural world, replacing it with pure instrumentality.

Exam Alert

Marx vs. Durkheim on Social Dysfunction: Both diagnose dysfunction in post-industrial Europe, but from different vantage points. Marx locates the cause in **economic relations** (alienation). Durkheim locates it in the **cultural/moral sphere** (anomie). An exam comparing these two *must* identify both the shared object of analysis and the different explanatory frameworks.

Chapter 5

Émile Durkheim: Social Facts, Solidarity, and Anomie

Key Thinker: Émile Durkheim (1858–1917)

Established sociology as an **academic discipline**. While Comte coined the word “sociology,” Durkheim gave it rigorous **methods**. A committed **empiricist**—he believed data and facts were as uncontested as possible and tried to make sociology *objective*.

Key methodological commitment: Like Marx, Durkheim insists that the **individual is not the unit of study**. He uses the metaphor of the **puppet**: society and social norms pull the strings. (But note the **structure–agency debate**: humans also have the agency to “cut the thread” between puppet and puppeteer.)

5.1 Structural Functionalism (Background)

Durkheim is close to—but not identical with—the structural-functionalist position (classically associated with Talcott Parsons).

The Body Metaphor

Structural functionalists see society like a **living body**: every organ exists to perform a function without which the body cannot survive. Similarly, every social stratum performs a function that gives society its integrity and wholeness.

Implication for Stratification

Political, spiritual, and economic systems all exist because they perform necessary functions—this is why stratification exists.

5.2 Social Facts

“Any way of acting, whether fixed or not, capable of exerting over the individual an external constraint.” —Émile Durkheim

Material Social Facts

Tangible, observable structures—bureaucracy, laws, architecture.

Non-Material Social Facts

Culture, social institutions, norms, values, collective consciousness. Durkheim focused primarily on these.

Durkheim insisted: treat social facts as *things* (study them objectively, like physical objects) and *explain social facts with other social facts*—not with individual psychology. This was his way of making sociology a genuine, independent science—separate from psychology or biology.

Social facts are:

- (i) **External** to the individual.
- (ii) **Coercive**—they compel behaviour through varying degrees of pressure, from mild social disapproval to extreme consequences.

Case Study: Social Facts in Everyday Life

Divorce rate: A person in an unhappy marriage thinks twice in a low-divorce-rate society but feels freer to leave in a high-divorce-rate society. The *number itself*—a social fact—shapes individual decisions.

Economic growth rate: Impacts consumption patterns, risk-taking, and purchasing decisions.

Population distribution: Living in a homogeneous vs. multicultural community profoundly shapes one's worldview.

Caste in India: Social norms are enforced through coercion—from mild (a mother scolding a child for not saying *namaste* to a neighbour) to extreme (honour killings for marrying outside one's caste).

Interdisciplinary Link

Education as Defamiliarisation: The professor cited the scientist who wrote India's first education policy (1960s), who argued that higher education should produce people who “upset the apple cart.” Universities are where people meet those unlike themselves (the vegetarian roommate paired with a non-vegetarian from Kannur) and are forced to revise their assumptions. This is a *social fact* reshaping individual behaviour.

5.3 Mechanical Solidarity vs. Organic Solidarity

Durkheim's central question: *How does society sustain itself and maintain coherence?* His answer traces a historical transition:

Mechanical Solidarity	Organic Solidarity
Pre-modern, simple, small, rural	Modern, complex, industrial, urban
Everyone similar—same beliefs, morals, rituals	People different but interdependent (division of labour)
Collective conscience strong; community identity dominates individual	Collective conscience weakened; individual identity grows
“If God has placed me here, I must accept it”	Individual agency; competing moral authorities
Deep personal investment in others’ lives	Transactional interdependence
Consensus on what is moral	Culture wars over fundamental values

Industrialisation broke down the collective conscience of traditional society. The **division of labour** (everyone specialising in different jobs) created organic solidarity—people needed each other precisely because they were different. A doctor needs a farmer; a teacher needs a plumber. *Interdependence replaces similarity.*

Case Study: Mechanical Solidarity Surviving in India

In Indian small towns, if a crisis occurs, 15–20 neighbours arrive unbidden to take over logistics. A death in the family means the community provides food for days. Nothing is secret—the shopkeeper tells your father you bought cigarettes. This deep investment in others’ lives is a remnant of mechanical solidarity—people help not because they expect reciprocation, but because “this is how society functions.”

Case Study: The Protestant Reformation and Competing Moral Authorities

The rise of the **Protestant Church** exemplifies modernity’s fragmentation: Protestantism asserts that individuals have a *direct connection* with God and can interpret scripture themselves—no need for the Pope. This was empowering for marginalised groups: Black Protestant churches in America allowed African Americans to argue that God did not create them as inferior. Martin Luther King Jr. and others drew on this tradition. But the multiplication of moral authorities is precisely what creates the conditions for **anomie**.

5.4 Anomie

Definition

A state of **normlessness**—the breakdown of social norms and collective moral consensus. Individuals are left without a sense of direction, purpose, or belonging.

Cause

The transition from mechanical to organic solidarity is *not automatic*. It leaves a void—the loss of collective conscience, deep personal connectivity, and shared

moral anchoring.

Consequence

Durkheim's landmark study of **suicide** (1897) in modern Europe: he pored over empirical data to understand why there was a sudden spiral of suicides. His answer: European society was suffering from anomie.

5.4.1 Durkheim's Typology of Suicide

Egoistic Suicide

Too little social integration—the individual is insufficiently connected to the group. Catholics (more socially integrated) had lower suicide rates than Protestants (more individualistic).

Altruistic Suicide

Too much social integration—the individual sacrifices themselves for the group. Example: soldiers dying in battle.

Anomic Suicide

Lack of regulation during crisis—when rapid social change leaves individuals without moral guidance.

Case Study: The Syrian Refugee Crisis and the Longing for Collectivity

The professor recounted a 2015 conference in Malmö, Sweden where a scholar argued European society lacked belonging and needed “cohesion.” When Syrian refugees arrived, Swedish citizens *spontaneously* opened church doors, collected warm clothes, cooked food—and this collective action gave them a **sense of purpose** absent in their highly individualised society. The South Asian scholars present were baffled: they had spent their lives trying to *escape* the suffocating collectivity of Indian small-town life, while Europeans were craving exactly that.

Critical Reflection: Anomie and the Rise of Right-Wing Movements

The professor drew a direct line from Durkheim's anomie to contemporary politics: the global rise of right-wing movements (Trump, Erdoğan, movements in Denmark, India) harnesses the sense of **normlessness**—“we have lost something from the past.” People desperately want a clear moral code. The right offers the *illusion* of restored consensus. **Important:** Durkheim is *not* arguing for a return to the pre-modern past.

5.5 Religion and Society

In *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), Durkheim made a striking claim: when people worship God or a totem, they are actually worshipping *society itself*. Religion serves to create social solidarity—it binds people in a “moral community called church.”

This view is deeply conservative: if society is sacred, it should not be overthrown, only reformed. It also explains why Durkheim's solution to anomie involves building *new* collective institutions rather than dismantling the old order.

5.6 Durkheim's Solution: Occupational Associations

Durkheim's prescription: build new **networks of belonging, solidarity, and mutual assistance** suited to modern industrial society. These should be **occupational groups**—managers, workers of a department—that provide solidarity across caste and other divisions. The professor cited steel-town workers in Bhilai who developed strong cross-caste solidarity on the factory floor.

Exam Alert

Durkheim's central question is *not* “why does capitalism emerge?” but rather “**how does society sustain itself?**” From the very framing of his research question, Durkheim reveals his structural-functionalist orientation. Contrast this with Marx (exploitation and conflict) and Weber (meaning and action).

Chapter 6

Max Weber: Verstehen, Rationality, and the Iron Cage

Key Thinker: Max Weber (1864–1920)

Weber builds his framework in **explicit engagement and contestation** with both Marx and Durkheim. He borrows elements from each, expands on some, and rejects others.

Key difference from Marx and Durkheim: While both Marx and Durkheim insist the individual is not the unit of study, **Weber focuses on individual action and the meanings individuals assign to their actions.**

Key critique of Marx: Marx's theory is **uni-causal**—one cause (the economy) drives everything. Weber argues that history and social life have *multiple causes*, and culture, religion, and ideas can themselves shape the economy.

6.1 Verstehen (Understanding)

Core Concept: Verstehen

German for “to understand” or “to interpret.” Studying society is fundamentally different from studying nature. Social action is *meaningful*—people attach **subjective meaning** to what they do. The sociologist must try to *understand* the meaning actors give to their actions, not just observe external behaviour. There is no objectively “correct” meaning—it depends on context and subjectivity.

Weber noted that most action is not fully conscious—people often act out of habit, emotion, or tradition without fully understanding why. This is why the interpretive approach is essential.

Example from Class

A person wearing a full suit on a 14-hour flight. Merely observing the behaviour tells you nothing. *Verstehen* asks: is this person going to a business meeting? Do they associate formality with self-respect? Is it a cultural norm?

6.2 Ideal Types of Social Action

Weber identifies four “pure forms” of social action—analytical tools, not empirical descriptions:

1. Instrumental Rational (*Zweckrational*)

Calculates means and ends logically; acts to achieve specific goals efficiently.
The dominant form in modern capitalist societies.

2. Value Rational (*Wertrational*)

Action guided by a deep commitment to a value or principle, *regardless of consequences*. Example: a whistleblower sacrificing their career for truth.

3. Emotional/Affectual Action

Driven by feelings and emotions—spontaneous, not calculated.

4. Traditional Action

Follows deeply ingrained habits and customs—“the way things have always been done.”

Weber observed that modern society is increasingly moving toward *instrumental rational* behaviour in all spheres.

Critical Reflection: Why Ideal Types Matter

Human behaviour is always a *mixture* of these types. The ideal types are Weber’s analytical toolkit for *disaggregating* complex action into comprehensible components.

6.3 Weber on Capitalism: The Protestant Ethic

The Question

Why did capitalism emerge in Western Europe and not elsewhere?

Weber’s Answer

Capitalism arises because of a particular subset of Christianity: **Calvinist Protestantism** (from handwritten notes: “Weber: Why Capitalism rose — Calvinists”).

The Calvinist Ethic

Calvinists believed in an individual connection with God (no Church mediation needed). They instituted a cultural ethic of **hard work, frugality, and reinvestment of profits**—not for personal indulgence but as a sign of divine favour. This “Protestant ethic” created the cultural preconditions for rational, systematic capital accumulation.

Culture as Driver

Unlike Marx (who sees economic structures as primary), Weber argues that **cultural and religious ideas** can *independently* drive economic transformation. They are often seen as complements—both factors matter.

Interdisciplinary Link

History ↔ Sociology: Weber's thesis demonstrates that understanding capitalism requires understanding *religious history*. The Reformation is not merely a theological event—it is a sociological one, reshaping the relationship between faith, labour, and wealth accumulation.

6.4 Rationalisation and the Iron Cage

Rationalisation

Weber saw modernity as a process of **rationalisation**—the increasing domination of calculation, efficiency, and formal rules over tradition and emotion in all areas of life.

Bureaucracy

A product of **instrumental rationality**. Institutions prioritise efficiency and goal-achievement over emotional and value-based considerations. Bureaucracy is rational, hierarchical, rule-governed—and **dehumanising**. It is “domination through knowledge.”

The Iron Cage (*stahlhartes Gehäuse*)

Weber's metaphor: the relentless pursuit of efficiency and rationality leads to a loss of individual autonomy, creativity, and purpose. “Specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart.” We become prisoners of the very systems we created to liberate ourselves.

Weber's Pessimism

Unlike Marx (who believes revolution can overthrow capitalism) and Durkheim (who believes new forms of solidarity can restore cohesion), Weber sees the iron cage as an *inescapable* consequence of rationalisation.

6.5 Three Types of Authority

Weber identified three types of **legitimate authority**—the basis on which people accept being ruled:

Traditional Authority

Authority derived from custom and tradition—“it has always been this way.” Example: monarchies, tribal chiefs.

Charismatic Authority

Authority derived from the extraordinary personal qualities of a leader. Example: Gandhi, Hitler, Martin Luther King Jr. Unstable—depends on the individual's continued charisma.

Rational-Legal Authority

Authority based on formal rules and procedures—the basis of modern states and bureaucracies. Presidents, prime ministers chosen by formal procedures. The dominant form in modernity.

6.6 Weber on Class: Beyond Economics

Marx on Class	Weber on Class
Defined <i>solely</i> by relationship to the means of production	A combination of three dimensions
Bourgeoisie vs. proletariat	1. Economic capital (wealth/income) 2. Status (social prestige, honour) 3. Power (influence, demographic heft)
Class is objective and binary	Class is multidimensional and graduated

Case Study: Caste as Weberian Status

A Brahmin may have less economic capital than a wealthy merchant, but commands enormous *status* (social prestige) and *power* (influence over religious and social matters). A purely Marxist analysis based on economic relations would miss this crucial dimension.

Case Study: M.N. Srinivas and “Dominant Caste”

The Indian sociologist M.N. Srinivas used the Weberian framework to develop the concept of **dominant caste**—a caste that combines *numerical strength*, *land ownership* (wealth), and *social prestige* to dominate village society. This has been successfully used to explain political trends in India. It is a quintessentially Weberian analysis: all three dimensions of stratification must be considered together.

Chapter 7

Comparing the Founding Fathers

7.1 Synoptic Comparison

	Karl Marx	Émile Durkheim	Max Weber
Central Question	Why does capitalism create exploitation and conflict?	How does society maintain coherence?	Why does capitalism emerge <i>here</i> and <i>now</i> ? What meanings drive action?
Unit of Analysis	Social classes (not individuals)	Social facts (not individuals)	Individual action and meaning
Methodology	Dialectical materialism	Empiricism, positivism	Verstehen
Key Concepts	Alienation, class conflict, modes of production, surplus value	Social facts, solidarity, anomie	Verstehen, ideal types, iron cage, Protestant ethic
Diagnosis of Dysfunction	Economic alienation	Anomie (normlessness)	Rationalisation and dehumanisation
Cause of Capitalism	Material contradictions; class struggle	(Not primary focus)	Calvinist Protestant ethic
View of Individual	Product of the system (puppet)	Product of social facts (puppet)	Agent who assigns meaning to action
Solution/Outlook	Revolution; overthrow capitalism	Build new occupational solidarities	Pessimistic: iron cage is inescapable

7.2 Points of Convergence

- All three explain the same historical phenomenon: the transformation of European society in the 17th–19th centuries and the emergence of capitalism.

- All three recognise that modernity has produced significant social dysfunction.
- Marx and Durkheim both insist on studying structures and systems rather than individuals.
- Weber borrows from both but adds the dimension of *meaning* and *individual action*.

7.3 Points of Divergence

- **Economics vs. Culture:** Marx privileges economic base; Weber privileges cultural/religious ideas; Durkheim privileges social/moral bonds.
- **Conflict vs. Consensus:** Marx sees society as driven by conflict between classes. Durkheim sees society as tending towards consensus. Weber occupies a middle ground.
- **Structure vs. Agency:** Marx and Durkheim lean towards structural determination. Weber insists on individual agency and subjective meaning.
- **Optimism vs. Pessimism:** Marx is revolutionary; Durkheim is reformist; Weber is pessimistic.
- **Uni-causal vs. Multi-causal:** Marx has one primary cause (the economy). Weber insists on multiple causes (economy, culture, religion, ideas all matter independently).

Critical Reflection: The Professor's Meta-Point

The reason for teaching all three thinkers is to demonstrate **how the social sciences work**: different methods lead to different insights, and competing interpretations can coexist. A Marxist and a Weberian can study the same factory floor and produce valid but radically different analyses. “The process is almost as important as the final product.”

Chapter 8

Sociological Frameworks and Social Stratification

Social stratification—the way society is organised into layers of unequal groups—is one of sociology’s central topics. The three major frameworks explain it very differently.

8.1 Three Frameworks on Stratification

Structural Functionalism (Durkheim + Parsons + Merton)

Dominant in India until the 1970s. Inequality exists because it is *necessary* for society to function. Different positions perform different roles; those performing more important roles get more rewards. Various groups *consent* to stratification because they are organically connected to the system. **Critique:** This approach ends up *rationalising and justifying* social inequality rather than questioning it.

Conflict Theory (Marx)

Stratification is *not* natural or necessary—it is the result of specific historical processes driven by conflict and power. The powerful create systems that maintain their dominance (e.g., caste was not always birth-based—it became so through historical processes). Conflict theories see stratification as an exercise of power.

Weberian Approach

Uses class, status, and power *together* to explain stratification. Status distinctions (prestige) can arise independently of economic class. Power is related to membership in organisations, not just wealth. All three dimensions must be considered.

8.2 The Three W's: Bases of Social Stratification

Core Concept: The Three Dimensions of Stratification (Weber)

Wealth

Associated with education, income, and occupation.

Power

The ability of one party to affect the behaviour of another, tied to membership in organisations (not just economic status).

Prestige

The distinction or reputation by which people are subjectively evaluated.

Together, these three determine social position.

Chapter 9

Social Structure: A Theoretical Debate

The concept of “social structure” is fundamental to sociology—but there is no agreement on what it actually means!

Core Concept: Basic Definition of Structure

Structure = the way the parts of an entity are *interconnected* so that the entity emerges as an integrated whole. In society, the “parts” could be individuals, groups, roles, or institutions—and there is debate about which ones matter most.

The debate has two core questions:

1. *What are the parts* among which structural relations exist—individuals? groups? roles?
2. Is structure *real and observable*, or is it a *model/abstraction* that the researcher constructs?

9.1 Radcliffe-Brown: Structure as Observable Reality

View Social structure is *real and observable*—“just as real as individual organisms.”

Definition

Structure = the set of actually existing relations between persons at a given moment. Study it like a natural scientist studies biology.

Structural Form

The general pattern abstracted from specific instances. A person is a “complex of social relationships.”

Approach

“Sociological functionalism”—his key concept was *structural continuity* of society. He focused on how social institutions maintain integration. He called his

approach “structural-functional” because structure is only observable when it functions.

9.2 Evans-Pritchard: Structure as Groups Over Time

View Structure = relations between *groups* (not individuals) that have consistency and constancy over time.

Key Idea

Individuals come and go, but groups endure. Social structure is the anthropologist’s abstraction from reality.

Methodological Position

Social anthropology is a kind of *historiography* (like history), not natural science.

9.3 Lévi-Strauss: Structure as Model

View Social structure is a *model* built by the researcher—it has nothing to do with empirical reality directly.

Key Idea

Like a linguist who finds the grammar underlying speech, the structuralist finds the underlying logic beneath social behaviour.

Two Distinctions

- **Conscious models** (how people see themselves) vs. **Unconscious models** (deeper structures the researcher uncovers).
- **Mechanical models** (what people say they do) vs. **Statistical models** (what people actually do).

Case Study: The Music Example — Leach’s Illustration of Lévi-Strauss

A piece of music can be transformed into printed notes, finger movements on a piano, sound waves, grooves on a record, electromagnetic signals—all completely different forms. Yet the underlying *structure* is the same. Similarly, different societies may look very different on the surface but have the same underlying structure. Lévi-Strauss showed this by comparing Australian Aboriginal totemic society and the Indian caste system—they had the same deep structure.

9.4 Nadel’s Synthesis: Structure as Roles

S.F. Nadel argued that social structure is neither purely observable nor purely abstract—it is social reality viewed at a level of abstraction. For him, the components of social structure are **roles**: patterns of interconnected roles constitute the structure.

Exam Alert

Exam questions on social structure often ask you to distinguish between these three approaches. The key axis is: **Is structure real and observable (Radcliffe-Brown)? Or a researcher's abstraction about groups (Evans-Pritchard)? Or a formal model of deep logic (Lévi-Strauss)?**

Chapter 10

Functionalism, Neo-Functionalism, and Parsons

10.1 The Core Idea of Functionalism

Functionalism sees society as a whole system made of interconnected parts, where each part performs a function (makes a contribution) to the maintenance of the whole. It emerged in the early 20th century, dominated sociology until the 1970s, then faced severe criticism.

Core Concept: Five Core Premises of All Functionalists

1. Society is a system (like a solar or organic system).
2. It consists of interconnected, interdependent parts (institutions, groups, roles).
3. Each part performs a function contributing to the whole.
4. Change in one part affects others.
5. The whole is greater than the sum of its parts—society has its own identity (collective conscience).

10.2 Radcliffe-Brown vs. Malinowski

Radcliffe-Brown (Sociological Functionalism)

Focused on how social institutions maintain integration and structural continuity. Society is the unit of analysis.

Malinowski (Psychological Functionalism)

Started from the *individual*. Individuals have basic biological needs (food, sex, rest, safety) and culture is humanity's way of fulfilling those needs. He set up elaborate tables of biological impulses, cultural responses, and satisfactions. He called his concern with applying anthropology to real-world problems “practical anthropology.”

10.3 Talcott Parsons and the AGIL Model

Key Thinker: Talcott Parsons (1902–1979)

Produced the most elaborate functionalist theory. All “action systems” (including society) must solve four problems to survive—summarised in the acronym **AGIL**.

Letter	Function	Institution in Society
A — Adaptation	Get resources from the environment	Economy
G — Goal Attainment	Set and pursue collective goals; mobilise resources	Political System (Polity)
I — Integration	Coordinate and regulate relationships among parts	Legal System / Courts
L — Latency (Pattern Maintenance)	Maintain and transmit values; manage internal tensions	Family, Religion, Education

10.4 Merton's Corrections to Functionalism

Key Thinker: Robert K. Merton (1910–2003)

Parsons' student, but more cautious. Preferred “middle-range theories” (specific, empirically testable) over Parsons' grand theory.

Merton criticised three postulates of earlier functionalists:

1. **Functional unity:** Not all institutions benefit everyone equally.
2. **Universal functionalism:** Not everything in society has a positive function.
3. **Indispensability:** There are usually “functional alternatives” that can perform the same role.

Core Concept: Merton's Key Concepts

Function

Consequences that help a system adapt and survive.

Dysfunction

Consequences that harm the system's adaptation.

Manifest Functions

Intended, recognised consequences.

Latent Functions

Unintended, unrecognised consequences.

Example: When people participate in a religious ritual (*manifest function* = honouring God), they also unintentionally create social solidarity (*latent function*).

10.5 Criticisms of Functionalism

By the 1970s, functionalism faced serious attacks:

- It is *ahistorical*—doesn't deal with the past or historical change.
- It *freezes society* in a static picture, ignoring conflict and transformation.
- It has a *conservative bias*—justifies existing inequalities as “necessary” and supports the status quo.
- The *individual is passive*—just a product of social forces, with no creativity or agency.
- It is *teleological*—assumes everything has a purpose and exists to serve a function.

10.6 Neo-Functionalism (Jeffrey Alexander, 1985)

Neo-Functionalism tried to rescue and revise functionalism:

- Accepted conflict and change.
- Gave equal weight to individual action and social order.
- Tried to borrow insights from other theories (including Marxism).

Critics argued it was “old wine in new bottles”—the fundamental problems remained.

Critical Reflection: Functionalism and Inequality

Functionalism's most damning weakness: by arguing that all social institutions exist because they serve necessary functions, it *rationalises* inequality. Why do lower castes exist? Because they perform a function. Why do women stay in domestic roles? Because the family needs it. Critical theory, Marxism, and feminist sociology all reject this logic as ideology masquerading as science.

Chapter 11

Sociology in India: Colonial Roots to Contemporary Challenges

Sociology in India did not emerge organically from Indian society the way it did in Europe. It was imported—shaped first by colonialism, then by nationalism, and later by post-colonial critique.

11.1 Phase I: Colonial Modernity and Anthropology

When the British colonised India, they had a problem: they did not understand the people they were ruling. So colonial officers, missionaries, and trained anthropologists began systematically documenting Indian society—its castes, tribes, customs, and languages. The purpose was administrative convenience, not neutral science.

Two master narratives dominated:

1. The superiority of Western civilisation.
2. The belief in continuous capitalist progress.

The “West” was associated with “history, reason, and science”; the “East” with “nature, religion, and spirituality.” This was a false and biased distinction.

Core Concept: Anthropology as “Handmaiden of Colonialism”

Colonial anthropology categorised and classified Indian society—using census, ethnography, and even **anthropometric tools** (measuring skull sizes!) to divide people into races, castes, and tribes. The Ethnographic Survey of India produced District Gazetteers and the Imperial Gazetteer (26 volumes)—vast records of Indian life, filtered through a colonial gaze.

Case Study: Excerpts from the Bastar District Gazetteer

The gazetteer describes indigenous communities’ hunting practices, religious beliefs (worship of Danteshwari goddess, Jagannath, Budhi-mata), and food customs—all through a colonial lens that frames them as “aborigines” engaged in “depredations.” The language reveals how colonial documentation simultaneously recorded and *judged*

local lifeways, constructing them as pre-modern and in need of regulation.

11.1.1 The Indological Approach

Study of Indian society through the **scriptures** (Vedas, Manusmriti, etc.). It benefited **Brahmins**—who had a monopoly on these texts—by making them the authoritative voice on Indian society. It rationalised the caste hierarchy:

- Brahmins at the top, followed by Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, Shudras.
- Dalits (“untouchables”) outside the four-fold varna system entirely.
- **Normalised Brahminical power** and undermined other sources of authority (kinship groups, village communities, chiefly authority, factional parties).
- Caste became the “essence” of Indian society and civilisation.

11.1.2 The Bombay School

Key Thinker: Govind Sadashiv Ghurye

Headed the **first Department of Sociology in India** at the University of Bombay. Used the Indological approach.

Main Ideas:

- All those living in the territory of “India” possess a distinct, cohesive Indian identity defined by Hindu religion and Hindu civilisation.
- Indian society is organised by structures of caste, kinship, and family.
- Empirical studies but lack of theoretical perspectives—cementing “Hindu” values and a form of **cultural nationalism**.
- Employed Eurocentric categories and conceptual frameworks.

Institutional milestones: Teaching of sociology started in 1919 at the University of Bombay. By 1947, only three universities (Bombay, Calcutta, Lucknow) taught sociology/anthropology, with small centres in Poona, Mysore, and Hyderabad.

11.1.3 The Lucknow School

Key Thinker: Radhakamal Mukerjee & D.P. Mukherji

The Lucknow School took a very different approach from Bombay.

Key Features:

- Did *not* conflate sociology with anthropology.
- Analytical, empirical, and **interdisciplinary**.
- Present- and future-oriented (unlike Bombay’s focus on the ancient past).
- **Mukerjee** used ecology and regional analysis.
- **D.P. Mukherji** used dialectical (Marxist) logic while also engaging Indian tradition. He engaged the question of how Indian society should modernise without losing its distinctive traditions.

11.2 Phase II: Nation-State and “National” Sociology

After independence, two major figures shaped Indian sociology in very different ways:

Key Thinker: M.N. Srinivas (1916–1999)

Continued the functionalist/structural-anthropological tradition. Studied village India using ethnography.

Key Concepts:

Sanskritisation

Lower castes imitating upper-caste (especially Brahminical) practices—dietary habits, rituals, lifestyle—to claim higher social status over generations.

Westernisation

Adoption of Western (British) norms, values, and practices as a result of colonial rule.

Dominant Caste

A caste combining *numerical strength + land ownership + social prestige* to dominate village politics. Used to explain political trends across India.

Critique: Srinivas has been criticised for naturalising a “Savarna” (upper-caste) view of India and excluding tribes, religious minorities, and emerging groups. He also admitted to deliberately excluding the Harijan (Dalit) ward from his early fieldwork. When Dalits were interviewed separately, they described the system in terms of *power and exploitation*—not harmony.

Key Thinker: A.R. Desai (1915–1994)

Brought the **Marxist approach** to Indian sociology:

- Analysed contemporary social change and its unequal benefits.
- Critiqued mainstream nationalism, studying the nature of the ruling class.
- Included those left out by dominant interpretations (Dalits, adivasis, women).
- Used the historical method and political economy.

11.3 Phase III: Post-1970s Multiple Challenges

From the 1970s onward, sociology in India was challenged from multiple directions:

- Crisis in higher education as new and diverse students entered universities.
- **Social movements** of marginalised groups (Dalits, women, adivasis, OBCs) demanding recognition.
- The Indian state lost legitimacy as the sole driver of development.
- Growth of communalism and globalisation challenged secular sociology.
- Emergence of **Subaltern Studies**—studying the oppressed from their own perspective, not through elite sources.

- **Postcolonial Studies**—critiquing the Eurocentric assumptions built into the discipline.
- **Feminist, Dalit, and Adivasi critiques** of mainstream sociology.
- Growth of interdisciplinary research in media and cultural studies.

Interdisciplinary Link

History ↔ Sociology: The development of sociology in India cannot be understood without its entanglement with colonial history. The British need to administer the subcontinent *produced* the categories (caste, tribe, race) that Indian sociologists later inherited and had to critique.

Chapter 12

Village Studies in India

From the 1950s–1970s, “village studies” dominated Indian sociology. Social anthropologists went and lived in Indian villages, using **participant observation**, producing detailed accounts of village life. These were landmark studies—but also had serious limitations.

12.1 Why the Village?

After independence, India needed to understand its own society for development planning. The Ford Foundation and Planning Commission funded rural research. Sociologists saw the village as “India in microcosm”—a place where one could observe the “real” India: caste, kinship, religion, land relations. Robert Redfield’s concept of the **Little Community** influenced this approach.

12.2 Method: Participant Observation

The anthropologist chose a single village, stayed for 1–2 years, observed daily life, talked to people, and tried to produce a “holistic” account.

This “**field-view**” was seen as superior to the “**book-view**” of India produced by Indologists from ancient scriptures—it was based on what people actually *did*, not just what scriptures prescribed.

12.3 What They Found

12.3.1 Caste

Most studies found that caste was the primary organising principle of village life. The varna hierarchy (Brahmin–Kshatriya–Vaishya–Shudra–Untouchable) structured all social relations. But empirical research also showed that the middle of the hierarchy was *fluid*—caste statuses were not completely fixed.

12.3.2 Land and Class

Significant overlap between caste hierarchy and land ownership. Rich landowners were usually from higher castes; landless labourers were usually from lower castes/Dalits. But some argued land ownership mattered more than caste status itself.

12.3.3 Gender

Women (especially upper-caste) were confined to the domestic sphere, their sexuality controlled by men, and treated as subordinate. However, most data came from *male informants and male fieldworkers*—giving a biased picture.

12.4 The Jajmani System

The social structure of the village was often interpreted through the **Jajmani System**—a framework of reciprocal service relationships between castes:

- The dominant caste (landowners) gave patronage; artisan and service castes provided specialised labour in return.
- Many scholars emphasised the “harmony” and “interdependence” of this system.
- **Critics** (F.G. Bailey, Joan Mencher): the system was actually held together by *coercion* and economic dependency, not mutual goodwill.

12.5 Limitations of Village Studies

- Anthropologists usually stayed with *upper-caste dominant families*, giving them a skewed perspective. They avoided questions that might offend dominant interests.
- The studies were *conservative* in orientation—they documented structures, not conflicts or change.
- They were not **gender-sensitive**—women’s perspectives were largely absent.
- Srinivas himself admitted he “deliberately excluded the Harijan ward” initially. Dalits who were interviewed separately described the system in terms of *power and exploitation*—not harmony.

Critical Reflection: Village Studies as Ideological

Village studies were not politically neutral. By emphasising the “harmony” of caste relations and the “self-sustaining” village, they implicitly justified the existing social order. They are a good example of how functionalist assumptions—that every institution serves a function—can be used to naturalise oppression.

Chapter 13

Social Construction of Reality

One of the most influential ideas in sociology: reality—what we take to be “true” and “normal”—is not natural or God-given. It is *socially constructed*: created, maintained, and transmitted by human beings living together.

13.1 Berger & Luckmann’s Theory

Key Thinker: Peter Berger & Thomas Luckmann

The Social Construction of Reality (1966). Their key claim: Society exists as both *objective* and *subjective* reality. It is produced by human beings (externalisation), becomes an objective reality that constrains people (objectification), and is then internalised by individuals as their own understanding of the world (internalisation).

Core Concept: The Dialectical Process

Externalisation → Objectification → Internalisation

Humans create society (externalise their collective practices) → Society becomes a “given,” objective reality that constrains individuals (objectification) → Individuals internalise this reality as their own worldview.

This cycle explains how social norms, inequalities, and “common sense” are reproduced across generations.

13.2 How Reality is Constructed and Maintained

Reality is not given once and fixed. It is *fragile*—constantly renewed and maintained through rituals, routines, and social interaction.

13.3 Socialisation

Primary Socialisation (childhood/family)

The most powerful stage. We learn the basic rules of the world through the family. This is deeply emotional and hard to question later.

Secondary Socialisation (school, work, other institutions)

We learn role-specific knowledge for our place in the division of labour. Less emotionally deep, more “artificial,” and more easily revised.

13.4 The Role of Language

Language is the most important tool for constructing and maintaining social reality. It is not just a communication device—it accumulates knowledge, transmits values, and gives names (and therefore reality) to things. When we change language, we change reality. Language is itself a social fact—external to individuals, coercive, and shared.

13.5 Institutions and Legitimation

Institutions (family, state, religion, education) become “real” through **legitimation**—the process of providing them with a rationale, justifying why they exist and why people should follow their rules. The tools of legitimation include mythology, theology, philosophy, and science.

13.6 The Symbolic Universe

The **Symbolic Universe** is the overarching framework that makes all of a society’s institutions and beliefs feel coherent and meaningful. It arranges society in the mind of its members, filtering all experience through shared cognitive patterns.

When the symbolic universe is threatened, society uses:

- **Therapy:** Re-socialising deviants back into the accepted worldview.
- **Nihilation:** Dismissing and erasing alternative views as invalid, mad, or dangerous.

Case Study: Caste as a Social Construction

The caste system was not biologically natural—it was socially constructed, legitimated by Hindu scripture (the Indological approach), maintained through daily rituals and social interactions, and internalised by people across generations as “the way things are.” When lower castes began to question it (through education, social movements), they were challenging the *symbolic universe* that had maintained the system for centuries.

Interdisciplinary Link

Psychology ↔ Sociology: Primary socialisation shows the intersection: the family is both a psychological and a sociological institution. The deeply emotional nature of primary socialisation explains why people find it so difficult to question the values and worldviews instilled in childhood—even when they are objectively harmful.

Chapter 14

What Makes Someone a Sociologist?

Peter Berger's *Invitation to Sociology* (1963) begins by clearing away common misconceptions about what sociology is.

14.1 Wrong Images of the Sociologist

Sociologist as Social Worker

Many students think sociology is about “helping people.” But sociology is not a practice—it is an attempt to *understand*. Understanding may sometimes be used for social reform, but it can equally be used for other purposes. The sociologist's job is to report accurately on social terrain; others decide what to do with that information.

Sociologist as Statistician

Another image: sociologists as people who count things with surveys and computers. Statistics are a useful *tool*, but they do not make sociology. Without theoretical interpretation, data is just numbers. Kinsey's sex surveys, for instance, contain almost no sociology—they are raw data, not analysis.

Sociologist as Social Reformer

Comte himself saw sociology as a guide to progress. But sociological understanding can serve reform as easily as it serves oppression—the same knowledge about social solidarity can be used by a summer camp *or* a brainwasher.

14.2 Weber's Value-Free Sociology

Core Concept: Value-Free Sociology — Max Weber

Within sociology, there is only one fundamental value: **scientific integrity**. The sociologist tries to see what is there, regardless of personal preferences. This does not mean sociologists have no values as people—only that in their professional role, they try to observe clearly rather than judge. Like a good spy: your job is to report accurately, not to decide policy.

14.3 The Real Sociologist — Peter Berger

For Berger, the real sociologist is driven by an *insatiable curiosity* about human beings. Their “natural habitat” is wherever people gather. They are fascinated by the powerful and the marginalised, the sacred and the profane, the heroic and the completely ordinary.

The great excitement of sociology is not exploring distant, unknown worlds—it is finding that the *familiar world you live in is not what it seems*. Sociology shows us new layers of meaning in the ordinary. This is what Berger calls “**culture shock without geographical displacement.**”

Case Study: The Southern Caste System — Berger’s Example

Berger imagines a sociology class in the American South where students are bored—they already know about racial segregation. But the lecturer introduces the concept of “caste,” takes them to India, explains magical beliefs, economic interests, religious rationalisations. Suddenly India is not far away—and the familiar Southern system looks completely different. That moment of recognition—“things are not what they seem”—is the beginning of sociological thinking.

Critical Reflection: Berger’s First Wisdom of Sociology

“**Things are not what they seem.**” Social reality has many layers of meaning. Each new layer discovered changes the perception of the whole. Sociology is not a pastime—it is a passion, a demon that drives the thinker to keep asking its questions.

Chapter 15

Practice Questions and Exam Strategy

15.1 Short-Answer Questions

1. What is the difference between **data** and **information**? Use an example from the lecture.
2. Define **social fact** in Durkheim's terms. Distinguish between material and non-material social facts and give two examples of each.
3. What is the concept of **de-skilling** in the context of AI and work?
4. Distinguish between **mechanical solidarity** and **organic solidarity**.
5. What is **verstehen**? How does it differ from simple observation?
6. Define Weber's concept of **instrumental rationality** and give an example.
7. What is the concept of "**othering**"? How was it used to justify colonial domination?
8. Explain the **Indological approach** to studying Indian society and its critique.
9. What does Weber mean by **status**, and how does it differ from Marx's purely economic conception of class?
10. What is **anomie**? Name and explain Durkheim's three types of suicide.
11. What are Comte's **Law of Three Stages**? How does positivism emerge from this?
12. What is **surplus value**? Why is it the basis of Marx's theory of exploitation?
13. Explain the distinction between **base and superstructure** in Marx's theory.
14. What is the **Jajmani System**? How do functionalists and conflict theorists interpret it differently?
15. What did Berger & Luckmann mean by **externalisation, objectification, and internalisation**?

16. What are Weber's **three types of authority**? Give an example of each.
17. What is Parsons' **AGIL model**? Name the institution that performs each function.
18. Distinguish between **manifest** and **latent** functions (Merton). Give an example.
19. What is **Sanskritisation** (Srinivas)? Why has it been criticised?
20. How does **Subaltern Studies** challenge mainstream Indian sociology?

15.2 Essay Questions

1. **Compare and contrast** Marx's and Durkheim's explanations for social dysfunction in modern European society. What are the strengths and limitations of each approach?
2. Discuss the concept of the **sociological imagination**. Why is it important, and how does it differ from common-sense thinking? Use at least two examples from the lectures.
3. **How do Marx, Durkheim, and Weber each explain the emergence of capitalism?** What does the existence of three radically different answers tell us about the nature of social science?
4. Critically examine the role of **colonialism** in shaping the development of sociology, both in Europe and in India. How did colonial knowledge production create categories that persist today?
5. Discuss Weber's concept of the **"iron cage"** of rationality. How does instrumental rationality lead to both efficiency and dehumanisation? Is Weber's pessimism justified?
6. Explain how **digital platforms** reshape social interactions using sociological concepts discussed in class. Consider platformization, polarization, commodification, and the attention economy.
7. "The relationship between technology and social change is not one of simple cause and effect." Discuss this statement with reference to **de-skilling**, **digitalisation**, and **influencer culture**.
8. Discuss the relationship between the **state and citizenry** with reference to the social contract, the RTI Act, and the concept of privacy in the digital age.
9. How does Durkheim's concept of **anomie** help us understand contemporary phenomena such as the rise of right-wing movements globally?
10. Critically evaluate the **Bombay School** of Indian sociology. What were its contributions and limitations? How did the Indological approach shape—and distort—our understanding of Indian society?
11. Discuss the strengths and limitations of **village studies** as a method for understanding Indian society. What did they reveal about caste, class, and gender? What did they conceal?

12. “Society is not what it seems.” Discuss this statement with reference to Peter Berger’s concept of **sociological imagination** and Berger & Luckmann’s theory of **social construction of reality**.
13. Compare **Radcliffe-Brown’s, Evans-Pritchard’s, and Lévi-Strauss’s** understandings of social structure. What are the methodological implications of each position?
14. Critically evaluate **functionalism** as a theoretical framework in sociology. What are its core premises? Why was it so dominant, and why was it eventually rejected?
15. Discuss the three phases of **development of sociology in India**. How did each phase reflect the political and social context of its time?

15.3 Exam Strategy Tips

How to Write a Strong Sociology Answer

1. **Name the framework:** Always identify which theoretical perspective you are using (Marxist, Durkheimian, Weberian, Functionalist, etc.).
2. **Define key terms:** Begin by defining the core concepts. Use the formal definitions from slides/lectures.
3. **Show the “why”:** Don’t just describe *what* a theory says—explain *why* the thinker arrived at that position (their assumptions, historical context, method).
4. **Use examples:** Draw on case studies from class (RTI Act, Syrian refugees, caste system, online dating, influencer culture, Bhilai steelworkers, Swedish refugees, village studies).
5. **Compare and contrast:** The professor structures the entire course around comparison. Show how different thinkers approach the same phenomenon differently.
6. **Acknowledge complexity:** Avoid binary thinking. Note tensions, nuances, and the structure–agency debate.
7. **Connect biography to history:** Demonstrate the sociological imagination by linking individual experiences to structural forces.
8. **Remember “things are not what they seem”:** Look beneath the surface of any social phenomenon for the hidden structural forces at work.

Quick-Reference Glossary

- AGIL** (Parsons) The four functional prerequisites of any social system: Adaptation, Goal Attainment, Integration, Latency.
- Alienation** (Marx) Estrangement of workers from the product, process, fellow workers, and nature under capitalism.
- Anomie** (Durkheim) State of normlessness in society when shared moral consensus breaks down.
- Anthropometric Methods**
Colonial tools (skull measurement, etc.) used to classify people by race and “stock.”
- Bartering** Exchange of goods/services without money; persists in influencer marketing.
- Base and Superstructure**
(Marx) The economic base (modes of production) determines the superstructure (law, politics, culture, religion).
- Bureaucracy**
(Weber) Rational, hierarchical organisational form; product of instrumental rationality; “domination through knowledge.”
- Charismatic Authority**
(Weber) Authority derived from extraordinary personal qualities of a leader.
- Collective Conscience**
(Durkheim) Shared values and norms that hold pre-modern society together.
- Commodification**
Transformation of things (including human relationships) into tradeable commodities.
- Counter-Enlightenment**
Conservative reaction to the Enlightenment; emphasised tradition, collectivity, and social order over individual freedom.
- De-skilling** Loss of human skills/confidence as tasks are automated.
- Dialectical Materialism**
(Marx) History is driven by material/economic contradictions that produce conflict and change.

Digitalisation

Conversion of information and services into digital formats.

Dominant Caste

(Srinivas) A caste combining numerical strength, land ownership, and social prestige to dominate village society.

Dromology Study of movements and speed in society.

Dysfunction

(Merton) Consequences that harm a system's adaptation.

Empiricism

Knowledge derived from observation, experience, and data (Durkheim's method).

Externalisation

(Berger & Luckmann) The process by which humans create society through their collective practices.

Ideal Types

(Weber) Pure, abstract forms of social action used as analytical tools (not empirical descriptions).

Indological Approach

Study of Indian society through scriptures; privileged Brahminical knowledge.

Internalisation

(Berger & Luckmann) The process by which individuals absorb society's constructed reality as their own worldview.

Instrumental Rationality

(Weber) Goal-oriented action choosing the most efficient means; the dominant mode in modern capitalism.

Iron Cage (Weber) Metaphor for the dehumanising trap of bureaucratic rationality in modernity.

Jajmani System

A framework of reciprocal service relationships between castes in Indian villages; contested between harmony (functionalist) and coercion (conflict) interpretations.

Latent Functions

(Merton) Unintended, unrecognised consequences of social actions.

Law of Three Stages

(Comte) All societies pass through Theological → Metaphysical → Scientific (Positivistic) stages.

Legitimation

(Berger & Luckmann) The process of justifying social institutions so people accept them as valid.

Manifest Functions

(Merton) Intended, recognised consequences of social actions.

Mechanical Solidarity

(Durkheim) Social cohesion in pre-modern societies based on shared values and collective conscience.

Mode of Production

(Marx) The combination of productive forces and relations of production that forms the economic base.

Objectification

(Berger & Luckmann) The process by which humanly created society appears as an objective, external, coercive reality.

Organic Solidarity

(Durkheim) Social cohesion in modern societies based on interdependence through division of labour.

Othering Creating social boundaries that mark certain groups as different or inferior.

Participant Observation

Ethnographic method: the researcher lives within the community being studied.

Platformization

Rise of digital platforms as central intermediaries in modern life.

Polarization

Reduction of complex choices to binary options (Yes/No, swipe left/right).

Positivism (Comte) Society can and should be studied scientifically, using observable evidence.

Protestant Ethic

(Weber) The Calvinist work ethic (hard work, frugality, reinvestment) that helped create capitalism.

Rational-Legal Authority

(Weber) Authority based on formal rules and procedures; the basis of modern states and bureaucracies.

Reflexivity Awareness of one's own biases and how they shape research.

Sanskritisation

(Srinivas) Lower castes adopting upper-caste practices to claim higher social status.

Social Construction

(Berger & Luckmann) Reality is human-made—produced, maintained, and internalised through social life.

Social Contract

Implicit agreement among society's members to cooperate under shared rules.

Social Fact (Durkheim) External, coercive factor that constrains and shapes individual behaviour.

Social Stratification

How humans arrange themselves into hierarchical groups; studied through class (Marx), or class/status/power (Weber), or function (Durkheim/Parsons).

Sociological Imagination

(C. Wright Mills) Capacity to connect personal troubles to public/structural issues.

Subaltern Studies

Post-1970s approach: studying oppressed/marginalised groups from their own perspective, not through elite sources.

Surplus Value

(Marx) The extra value workers produce beyond their wages; the basis of capitalist profit and exploitation.

Symbolic Universe

(Berger & Luckmann) The overarching framework that makes all of a society's institutions and beliefs feel coherent.

Traditional Authority

(Weber) Authority derived from custom and tradition.

Value Rationality

(Weber) Action guided by deep commitment to a value or principle, regardless of consequences.

Verstehen (Weber) Interpretive understanding of subjective meanings actors assign to their actions.